Website Project Proposal: Empty Sandbox

Cameron McCullough
Southern Illinois University
ITEC 236: Web-based Applications in Information Technology
April 12, 2026

Add Headings (Format > Paragraph styles) and they will appear in your table of contents.

Description of Project

Empty Sandbox is an AI-native consultancy and product studio that partners with early-stage founders, student entrepreneurs, small businesses, and organizations to design, build, and modernize their digital presence and internal systems. The studio's internal team of developers, designers, and strategists takes on a wide range of engagements, from building new minimum viable products (MVPs) from the ground up to overhauling existing platforms, migrating legacy systems to more capable technology stacks, and delivering custom software solutions tailored to each client's specific operational needs.

A core area of practice for Empty Sandbox is digital transformation consulting, which involves assessing a client's current technology infrastructure and identifying opportunities to replace outdated or limiting platforms with more scalable, maintainable, and cost-effective alternatives.[1] This may include migrating a client's storefront from a template-based platform such as Squarespace to a more capable commerce solution such as Shopify, rebuilding a frontend for improved performance and user experience, or restructuring a backend to better support the client's business processes.

The studio integrates AI-assisted development tools into its workflow to accelerate delivery timelines and reduce costs without sacrificing quality. Every engagement begins with a structured discovery and consulting phase, rooted in lean product development principles that prioritize delivering working solutions quickly in order to validate assumptions and reduce wasted investment.[2] The internal team works directly with the client to assess existing systems, define objectives, and establish a clear execution roadmap before any development begins.

The Empty Sandbox website serves as the studio's central platform for marketing, client acquisition, and brand credibility. It is designed to communicate the team's breadth of capabilities, showcase completed work across different types of engagements, and guide prospective clients from initial awareness to a booked consultation. The site consists of six primary pages: Home, Pricing, Work, About, and Contact, with a Response confirmation page generated upon form submission. The About page incorporates a dedicated section outlining the studio's engagement process and methodology, and the Pricing page provides transparent tier-based pricing alongside a summary of each offering.

---

[1] George Westerman, Didier Bonnet, and Andrew McAfee, Leading Digital: Turning Technology into Business Transformation (Boston: Harvard Business Review Press, 2014)
[2] Eric Ries, The Lean Startup: How Today's Entrepreneurs Use Continuous Innovation to Create Radically Successful Businesses (New York: Crown Business, 2011).

Pages

Home

The Home page is the primary landing page and first impression of the studio. It features a bold hero section with the studio's tagline and a call-to-action button linking to the Contact page. Below the hero, the page includes a brief overview of what Empty Sandbox does, a highlights section featuring key statistics such as types of engagements completed and client categories served, and a preview of featured work from the portfolio. The page closes with a secondary call-to-action encouraging visitors to view pricing or book a consultation.

Pricing

The Pricing page provides transparent, tier-based pricing alongside a brief description of each offering. The three tiers are: a sprint engagement for focused, short-timeline deliverables; a full build package for clients who need a complete product or platform from the ground up; and a custom retainer option for ongoing development and consulting support. Each tier includes a description, typical timeline, and what is included. A call-to-action at the bottom of the page directs visitors to the Contact page to book a consultation.

Work

The Work page serves as the studio's portfolio and case study hub. Each featured project is presented with the project name, a brief description of the problem being solved, the solution built, the technologies used, and the outcome achieved. Projects are displayed in a visual card layout with thumbnail images. This page is critical for building trust with prospective clients by demonstrating the studio's range of capabilities across different types of engagements.

About

The About page introduces the studio and the people behind it. It tells the story of why Empty Sandbox was created, rooted in firsthand experience working alongside founders and organizations that lacked affordable, fast, and trustworthy development partners. The page highlights the studio's background in technology, entrepreneurship, and consulting, and outlines its core values of transparency, speed, and client ownership. This page also includes a dedicated section titled "How We Work," which walks visitors through the studio's four-phase engagement process: Discovery, Design, Build, and Launch.

Contact (Book a Call)

The Book a Call page serves as the studio's primary conversion point and functions similarly to the booking flows used by studios such as Creme Digital[3] and Aloa.[4] The page opens with a brief intake questionnaire that collects the visitor's first name, last name, email address, company or project name, service type of interest, and a short description of what they are looking to build or accomplish. Once the questionnaire is completed and submitted via the Submit button, or cleared using the Reset button, the visitor is directed to the Response page. The submitted data is passed via URL query string and remains visible in the page URL, allowing the studio to capture intake information alongside the scheduled meeting. The page is designed to be focused and friction-free, with a single clear objective of converting an interested visitor into a scheduled conversation.

Response

The Response page confirms that the visitor's submission was received and displays the submitted intake information pulled from the URL query string. Below the confirmation, the visitor is presented with an embedded calendar view showing available days and times to schedule their discovery call, functioning as the final step in the booking process. Once a time is selected, the meeting is confirmed and the visitor is given a summary of their scheduled call along with next steps. A link back to the Home page is included for visitors who wish to continue browsing the site.

Purpose & Objective

The primary purpose of the Empty Sandbox website is to serve as the studio's central platform for marketing, client acquisition, and brand credibility. The site exists to accomplish three core objectives.

The first objective is to establish trust and credibility with prospective clients by showcasing the studio's range of completed work, communicating its values and background, and demonstrating a clear and repeatable engagement process. In a market where many small development shops and freelancers lack transparency around their process and pricing, Empty Sandbox positions itself as a structured and accountable alternative.

The second objective is to generate qualified leads by guiding visitors through a deliberate conversion funnel. From the Home page, visitors are introduced to the studio's capabilities and directed toward the Pricing and Work pages to evaluate fit. Those who are ready to move forward are routed to the Book a Call page, where they complete a brief intake questionnaire and schedule a discovery call directly.

---

[3] Creme Digital, "Book a Call," accessed April 2026, https://www.creme.digital/book.
[4] Aloa, "Work With Us," accessed April 2026, https://aloa.co/hire.

The third objective is to clearly differentiate Empty Sandbox from traditional development agencies and independent freelancers. The studio's AI-assisted workflow, sprint-based delivery model, and full-service consultancy approach represent a distinct value proposition for clients who need quality work delivered quickly and at a cost that reflects their stage of growth.[5]

A secondary objective of the website is to function as a demonstration of the studio's own capabilities. The site itself is a portfolio piece, and its design and execution signal to prospective clients that Empty Sandbox can deliver polished, professional digital work across a range of engagement types.

Target Audience

The Empty Sandbox website targets three primary audience segments, each of which represents a distinct client profile with specific needs, constraints, and expectations.

The first and most immediate audience is early-stage founders and student entrepreneurs. This segment includes individuals who have a defined idea or early concept but lack the technical resources or development experience to build it themselves. They are typically operating with limited budgets, moving quickly, and in need of a partner who can provide both strategic guidance and hands-on execution. Student founders in particular represent a highly accessible entry point given the studio's roots in the university entrepreneurship ecosystem. This audience responds well to transparent pricing, fast turnaround times, and a clear engagement process that does not require them to understand the technical details of what is being built.

The second audience is small and local businesses seeking to modernize their digital presence or migrate away from limiting platforms. This includes businesses currently operating on template-based solutions such as Squarespace or Wix that have outgrown the constraints of those platforms and need a more custom, scalable, and maintainable alternative. A representative engagement for this audience might involve rebuilding a storefront frontend, migrating to a more capable commerce platform such as Shopify, or restructuring a backend to better support the business's operational needs.[6] This audience values reliability, clear communication, and a tangible return on their investment over technical sophistication.

The third audience is small organizations and nonprofits that need internal tools, membership systems, or operational infrastructure but do not have the budget to engage a traditional development firm. These clients often have recurring administrative problems that a well-scoped custom tool could solve permanently, but they have never had access to a development partner willing to work within their constraints. Empty Sandbox's consultancy model and flexible engagement tiers make it a viable option for this segment in a way that most agencies are not.

---

[5] Westerman, Bonnet, and McAfee, *Leading Digital*
[6] Westerman, Bonnet, and McAfee, *Leading Digital*

Planned Tools

The following tools and technologies are planned for use in the design, development, and deployment of the Empty Sandbox website.

Development and Structure

The site will be built using HTML5 as the foundation for all page structure and semantic content, CSS3 for visual design and layout including Flexbox, media queries, and a print stylesheet for the Home page, and JavaScript for interactive elements and dynamic behavior. jQuery will be used to implement the Slicknav responsive navigation plugin, which provides a mobile-friendly menu experience across all pages.

Design and Typography

Google Fonts will be used to embed a custom web font throughout the site, providing consistent and modern typography across all pages and devices. Visual planning and page layout decisions will be informed by wireframes and storyboards developed during the proposal phase.

AI-Assisted Development

The studio's internal development workflow incorporates AI-assisted coding tools to accelerate the writing, debugging, and refinement of code throughout the build process. These tools support the development team without replacing the judgment, architecture decisions, or quality standards applied by the team directly.

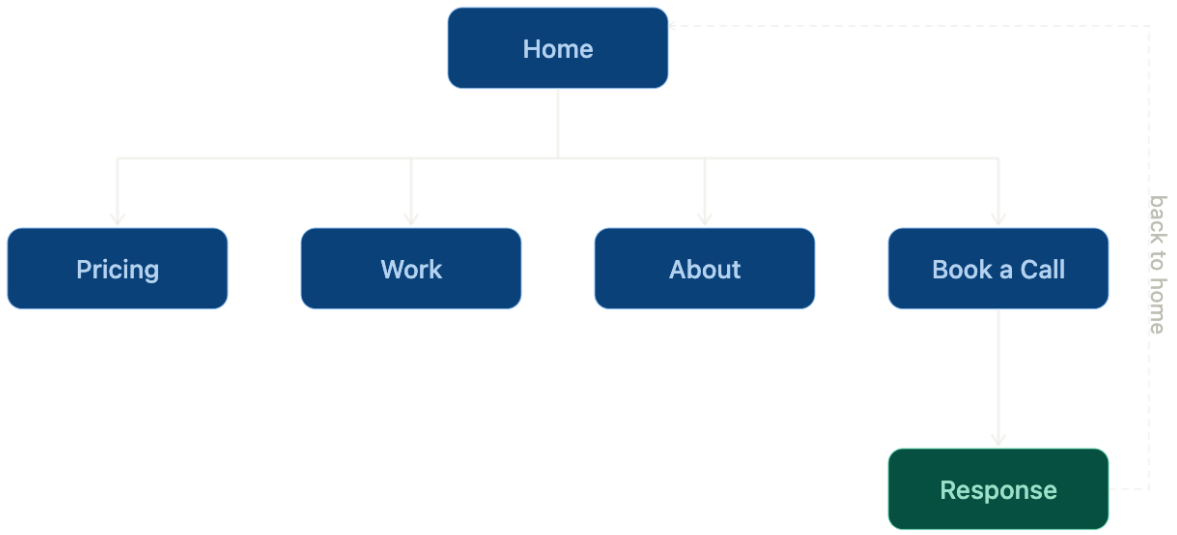
Version Control and Deployment

Git will be used for version control throughout the development process, tracking changes and maintaining a clean project history. The completed site will be deployed to GitHub Pages and submitted with a zipped project file as required by the course specifications.

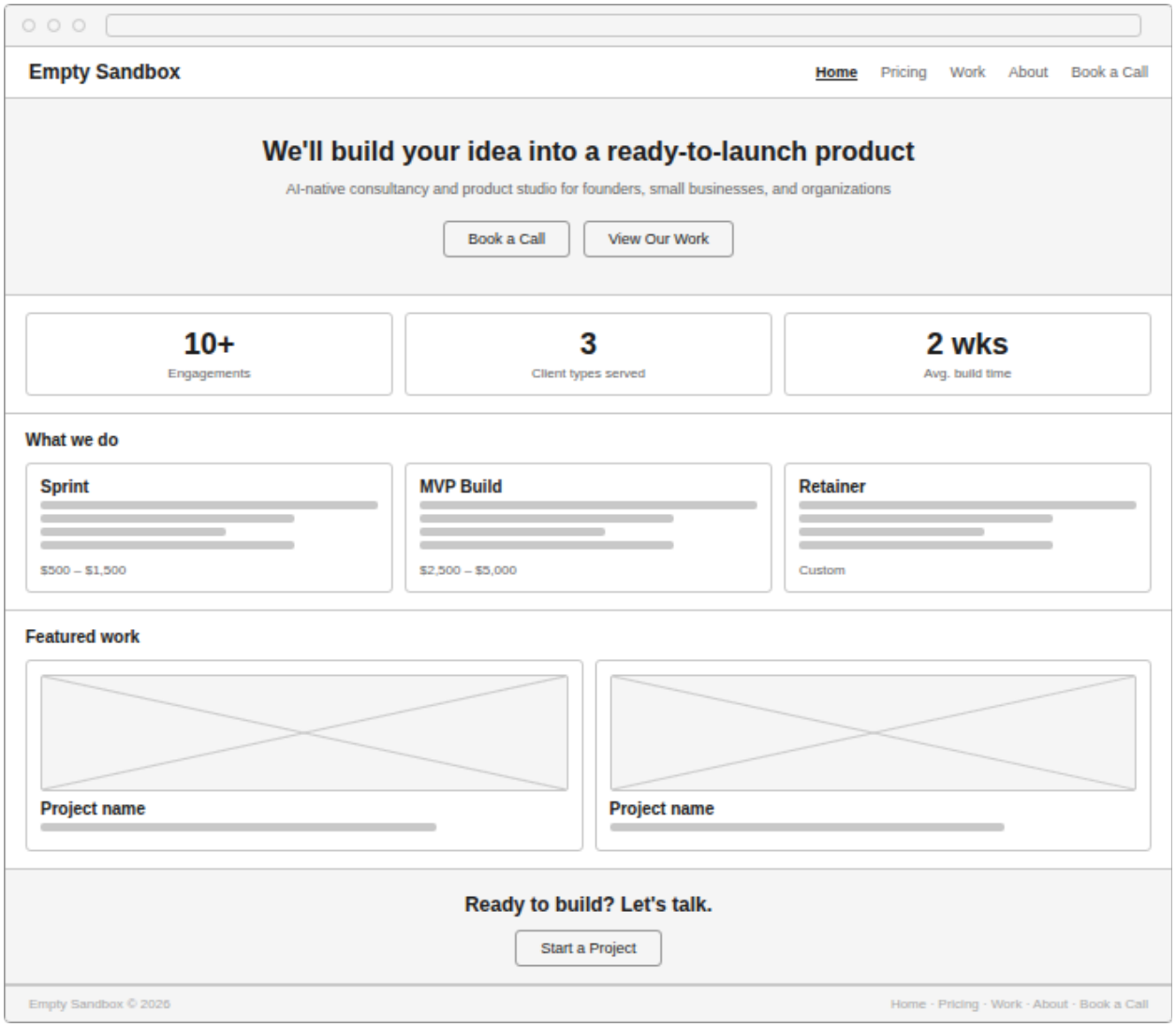
Code Editor

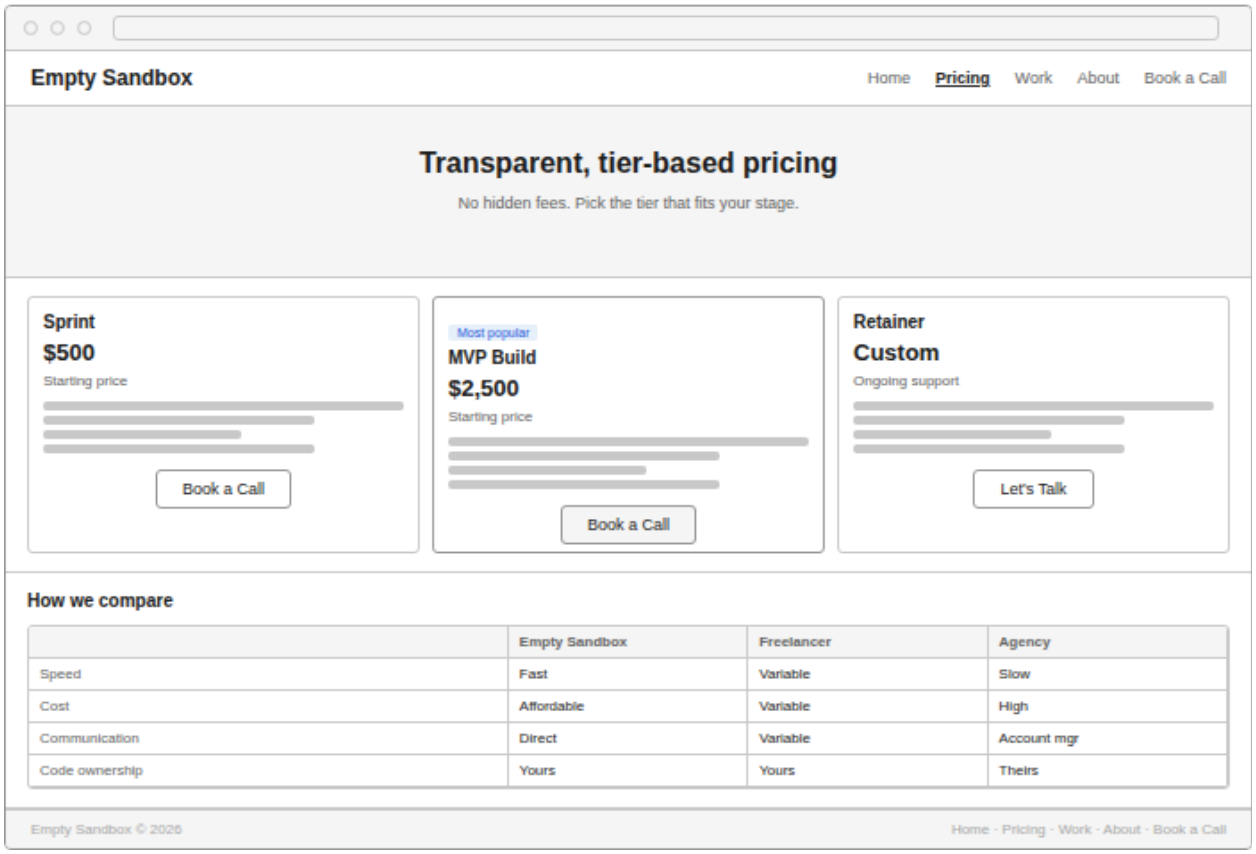
Visual Studio Code will serve as the primary code editor for all development work on the project.

Navigation Flow Diagram

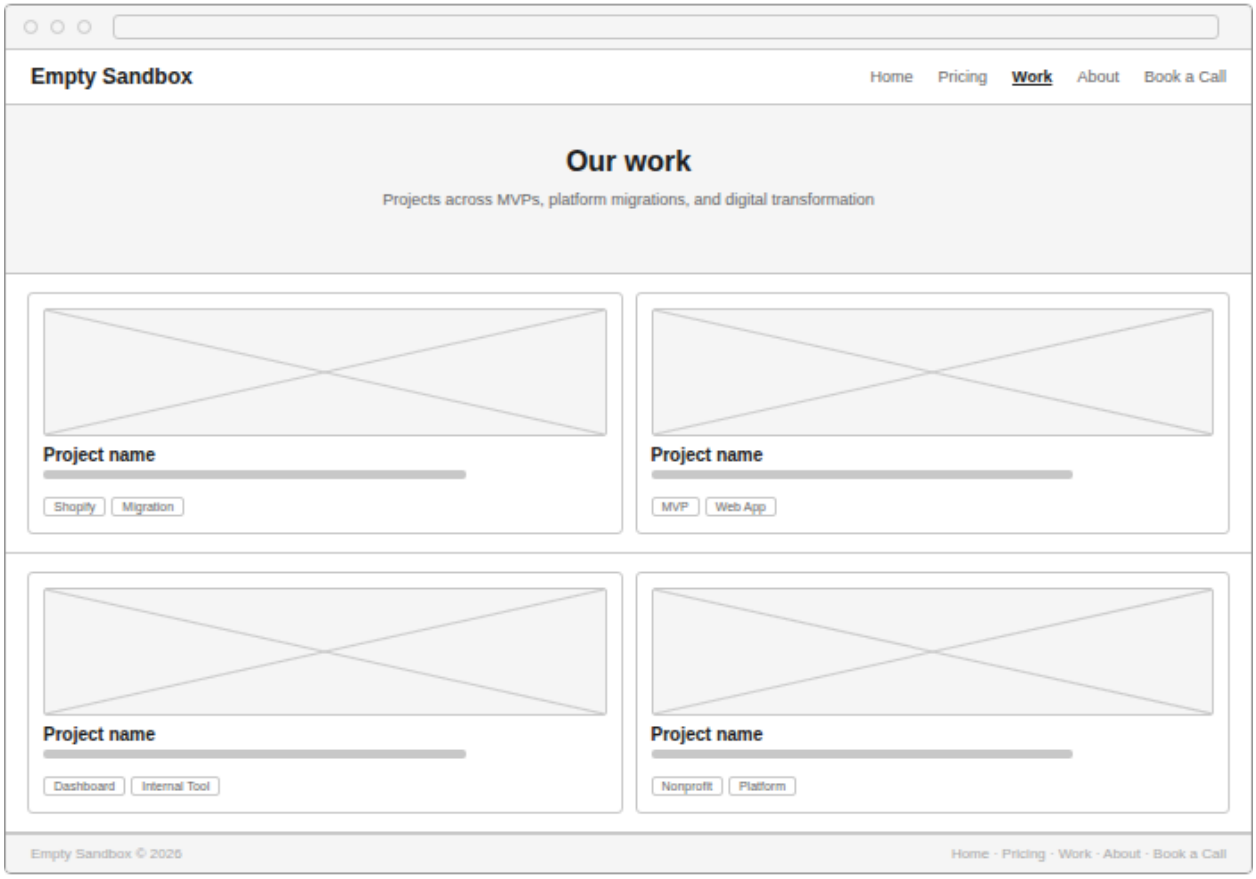


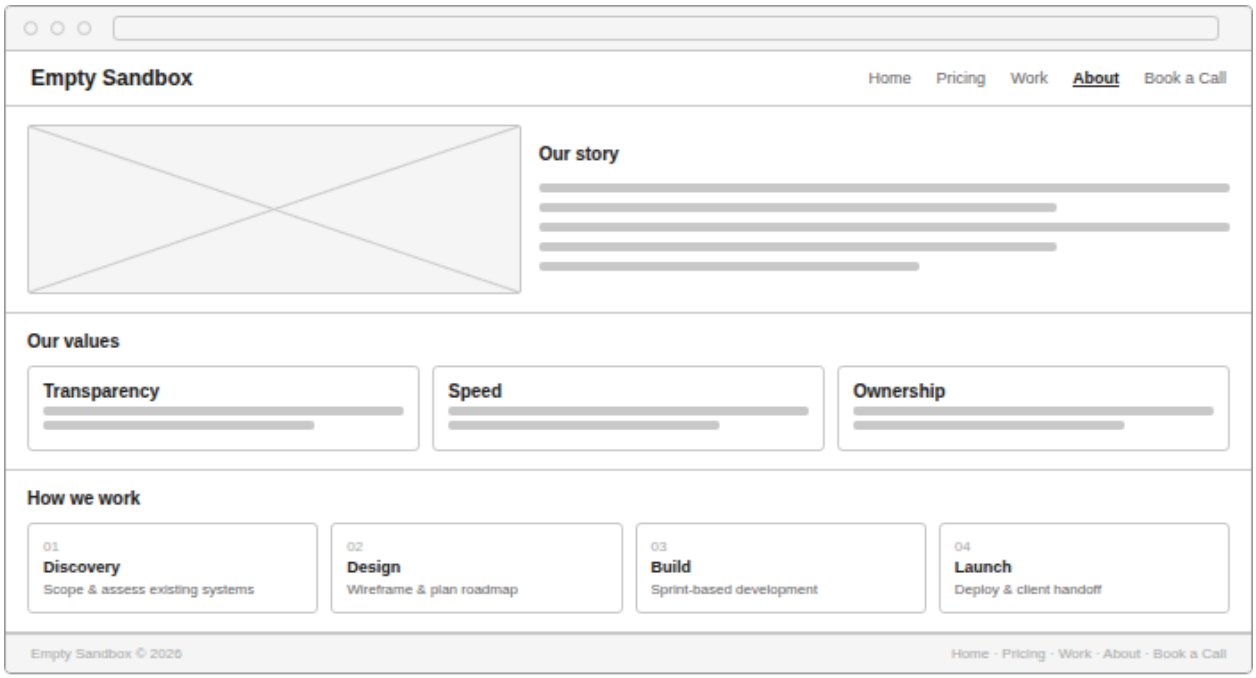
Storyboard

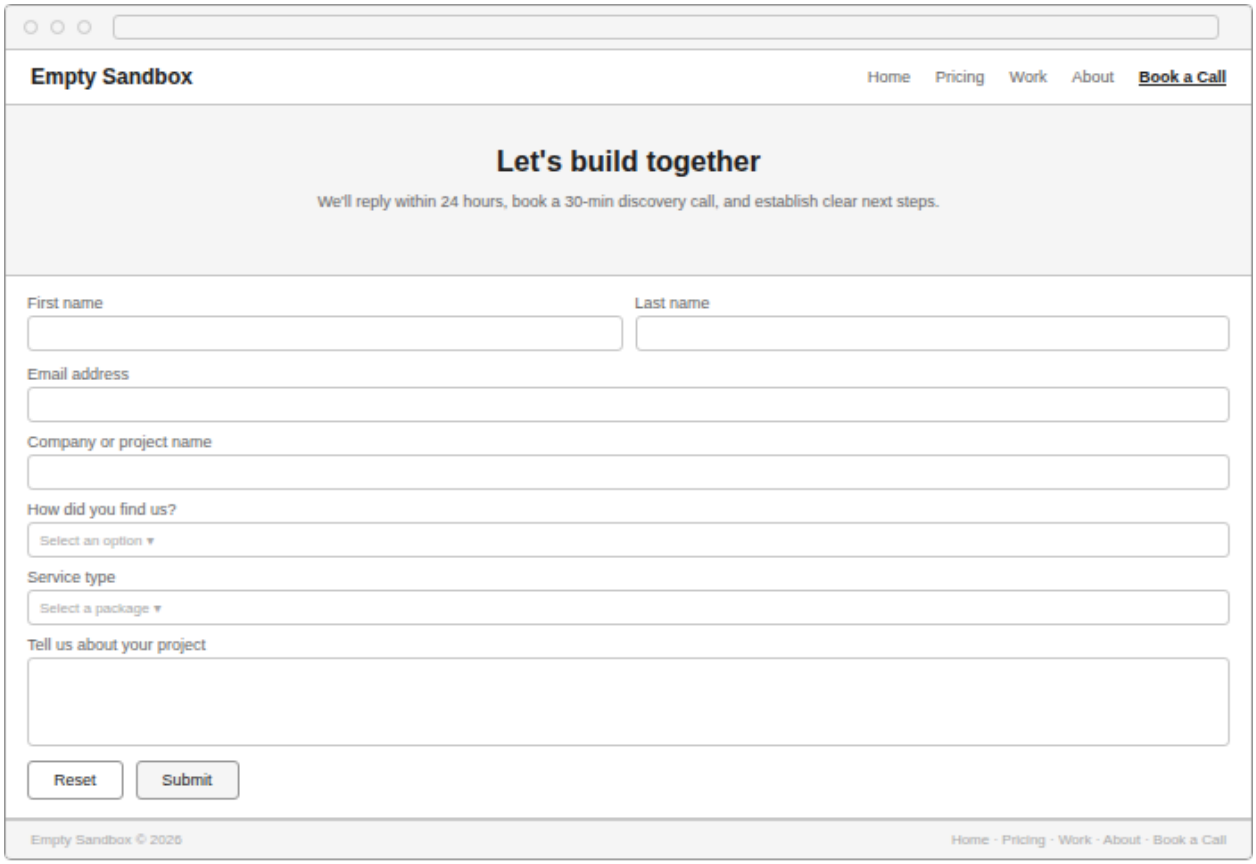

Empty Sandbox
Home
Pricing
Work
About
Book a Call
We'll build your idea into a ready-to-launch product
AI-native consultancy and product studio for founders, small businesses, and organizations
Book a Call
View Our Work
10+
Engagements
3
Client types served
2 wks
Avg. build time
What we do
Sprint
$500 – $1,500
MVP Build
$2,500 – $5,000
Retainer
Custom
Featured work
Project name
Project name
Ready to build? Let's talk.
Start a Project
Empty Sandbox © 2026
Home · Pricing · Work · About · Book a Call



	Empty Sandbox	Freelancer	Agency
Speed	Fast	Variable	Slow
Cost	Affordable	Variable	High
Communication	Direct	Variable	Account mgr
Code ownership	Yours	Yours	Theirs


Empty Sandbox
Home
Pricing
Work
About
Book a Call
Our work
Projects across MVPs, platform migrations, and digital transformation
Project name
Shopify
Migration
Project name
MVP
Web App
Project name
Dashboard
Internal Tool
Project name
Nonprofit
Platform
Empty Sandbox © 2026
Home · Pricing · Work · About · Book a Call


Empty Sandbox
Home
Pricing
Work
About
Book a Call
Our story
Our values
Transparency
Speed
Ownership
How we work
01
Discovery
Scope & assess existing systems
02
Design
Wireframe & plan roadmap
03
Build
Sprint-based development
04
Launch
Deploy & client handoff
Empty Sandbox © 2026
Home · Pricing · Work · About · Book a Call


Empty Sandbox
Home
Pricing
Work
About
Book a Call
Let's build together
We'll reply within 24 hours, book a 30-min discovery call, and establish clear next steps.
First name
Last name
Email address
Company or project name
How did you find us?
Select an option ▾
Service type
Select a package ▾
Tell us about your project
Reset
Submit
Empty Sandbox © 2026
Home · Pricing · Work · About · Book a Call

References

Aloa. “Work With Us.” Accessed April 2026. https://aloa.co/hire.

Creme Digital. “Book a Call.” Accessed April 2026. https://www.creme.digital/book.

Ries, Eric. *The Lean Startup: How Today’s Entrepreneurs Use Continuous Innovation to Create Radically Successful Businesses.* New York: Crown Business, 2011.

Westerman, George, Didier Bonnet, and Andrew McAfee. *Leading Digital: Turning Technology into Business Transformation.* Boston: Harvard Business Review Press, 2014.